

Inside the ring and outside

Compared to the last few WWE titles, we can definitely say that WWE 2K17 has definitely polished up on the in-ring experience. It's definitely an improvement over its predecessor thanks to the tweaks they've implemented and the addition of a few gameplay mechanics. They've increased the time you have to counter and use reversals. In addition to that they've now added the option to switch back to button-mashing for grapples and holds and such if you don't like the analog version.

Coming to those implementations, the first one is the new 'Rollout' mechanic. 2K's goal has always been to replicate the WWE TV experience as closely as possible. The rollout mechanic does this VERY well. This makes matches with multiple people much more enjoyable and less messy. The rollout allowed your character to escape or rollout of the ring when they were in a pinch or a pickle, much like the wrestling matches we see on TV, giving you some room to breathe and recover while the the remaining wrestlers duke it out in the ring.

Targeting is now set to manual by default, and is not as clunky as before, it's smoother and more fluid so you can quickly switch between targets. They've also made sure that you know who it is you're targeting with the name of your target hovering over your head for a brief while. All in all, it looks like WWE 2K17 is quite fine-tuned.

WWE 2K17 included two things we've been wanting to do in WWE games for a while now, the Backstage Brawl and the ability to take the match into the crowds. And we've gotta say it's quite fun, adding some variety to your matches. Our only complaint would probably be that the backstage areas are rather small, there's just 3 rooms you can enter and a rather small corridor. It's still fun, but could have been even more fun. We'd add that fighting in the crowds feels restrictive but then again we guess that's how it's supposed to feel.

Other than these two features, thanks to the gameplay tweaks and



the aforementioned mechanics the current game modes may actually give you a different and more enjoyable experience. Ladder matches for example have had a lot of changes made to them, from ladder placement to the way you attempt to grab the briefcase which now requires some finesse and timing on your part. Trust us, it's not easy and your ladder matches will be long. You've been warned!

Going Solo

WWE 2K17 is missing 2K Showcase. Meaning your only source of a progressive single player mode is 'My Career'. And we all know that My Career is a long grind with plenty of repetition. We get that going from newcomer to main eventer is not an overnight thing but it does get boring. They've attempted to spice it up with the 'Authority' interactions and being able to choose to become a 'Paul Heyman' guy. Which is quite entertaining; any of you who still follow the WWE know that Heyman definitely knows how to work the mic, and he's voicing himself here so it's bound to be good. Other than that is the addition of the promos, where you have to pick dialogue options to woo the crowd, with each state's crowd having different preferences. While the idea itself is not bad and has some level of depth to it, the implementation could have been better. However, there's plenty of customization options, especially when it comes to character creation, from editing your face, and moves, and outfit, to customising your entrance music and what appears on the titantron when you enter with videos you can cut and edit yourself.

Overall, you can still derive fun from the My Career mode but it'll eventually feel like a grind and the mode itself could use some polishing.

Other than that you of course have 'My Universe' where you can create your own version of WWE from scratch, from the wrestlers, to the arenas, the move sets, it's all upto you. They've really pulled all the stops to ensure that you get to do all the customization you want.

Graphics and Audio

When we said that WWE 2K17 is like a fine-tuned version of its predecessor we meant it. It looks pretty much the same as its predecessor, with very little visible improvement to the graphics. While many wrestler faces are amazingly accurate, some of them are off, and in most cases it's because of the hair, which looks dreadful in the game. There's also a lot of jagged edges and lines which we'd encountered while previewing the game as well which we had hoped would be polished by release. However, this didn't really diminish our overall experience.

Entrance music and wrestler dialogue is spot-on for the most part, we've got many wrestlers voicing themselves, can't go wrong there; The game soundtrack for menus and selection screens is also good with a nice selection of songs. The only major flaw would be the commentary, which was horrible. Repetition of phrases was pretty common. We must've heard them say the same thing in one match at least four to five times before we lost track.

The Verdict

WWE 2K17 is definitely enjoyable, the implementation of the new gameplay mechanics and tweaks to the existing ones – in our opinion – is a step in the right direction. Or maybe we're just biased against mindless button mashing. Teehee. They've fixed and worked on things they should've, but at the same time, not touched certain things that desperately needed fixing *cough*commentary*cough* among other things. But at the end of the day, we wouldn't mind ending the day with a round or two of WWE 2K17. *